

COOKT

Sculpted light. Life at the table.

Photography



COOKT makes a meal worth sitting down to. The photography gives everyday food presence: strong light, expressive ceramics, confident color and the small gestures of eating.

FROM THE SAVED BOARDS

Light, color, appetite.



Light draws the grid.

cookt / R006



Glaze, glass and sauce catch it.

cookt / R036



Strong color stays architectural.

ckt / R217



A gesture activates the table.

cookt / R039

Curated from Julia's saved pins. Visual references, not COOKT assets. Source links are attached to each image.

FROM THE SAVED BOARDS

A meal already in progress.



Let someone eat.

cookt / R015



A chair implies a person.

ckt2 / R151



Keep the plate at real scale.

ckt / R218



Compose for connection.

cookt / R007

Curated from Julia's saved pins. Visual references, not COOKT assets. Source links are attached to each image.

THE SYSTEM

Three ways into the meal.



01

The graphic table

Make someone stop. Make the meal clear.

Campaigns, homepage heroes, paid social, menu features.



02

Life at the table

Make COOKT feel part of a real day.

Brand stories, CRM, organic social, editorial.



03

Close appetite

Show what makes the dish worth eating.

Product detail pages, carousels, email, food stories.

THE SIGNATURE

Sculpted light.

A clear source.

A readable shadow.

A meal with presence.

Give light a direction.

Use a small, defined source from the side or behind. Keep one coherent shadow direction across food, hands and props.

Protect the food.

Hold detail in pale sauce and dark char. A little fill opens the dish; flags keep the surrounding shadows deep.

Let materials respond.

Glaze catches a highlight. Glass refracts it. Linen and wood absorb it. Use those differences to build depth.



A GRAPHIC COMPOSITION

Let the meal lead.

A complete dish. A strong field.
Space ready for the message.



Overhead makes the ceramic and the whole meal easy to read. Keep the visual rhythm simple enough to work at thumbnail size.

Use / campaign, homepage, paid social



A SHARED TABLE

Gestures give the picture a reason.

A hand entering the frame adds action without turning the image into a portrait. Keep wrists, utensils and plate scale believable. Capture the untouched setting too.

Use / organic social, community, editorial



IMPLIED PRESENCE

Set a place.

Use an empty chair, a normal glass of clear water and a ready meal to suggest someone about to sit down. Keep the light directional and the whole setting readable.



An empty chair, a glass, a moved fork or a folded napkin can suggest the person. Let light and the setting establish the occasion. Keep full-person scenes and portraits outside the current direction.

Use / CRM, editorial, occasion-led social

FOOD STYLING

Make the texture tangible.



01

Style the actual dish.

Work from the confirmed recipe and portion. Arrange existing ingredients for visibility; do not add protein, garnish or side dishes to imply a richer serving.

02

Keep the surface alive.

Refresh with the product's own sauce. Retain moist cut faces, distinct pasta and real char. Replace tired food before it becomes dry or clotted.

03

Give the ceramic room.

Keep food below the rim and leave enough glaze visible to identify the plate. Use natural, uneven placement; avoid identical chicken pieces arranged in a fan.

BUILD OUTWARD FROM THE DISH

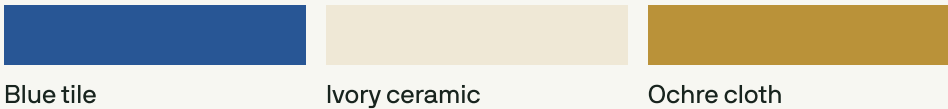
Anchor. Secondary. Tertiary.

Keep the product recognizable. Let the surrounding world change. Packaging colors identify the range; photographic set colors create contrast, atmosphere and rhythm.

01

Anchor

Start with the food and its ceramic. Preserve the glaze and the natural color of the meal.



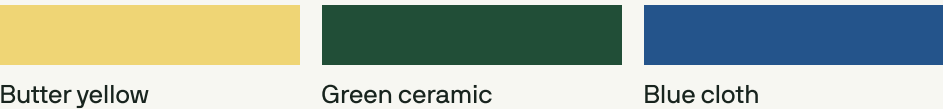
Cool field, warm food

Blue makes pale, creamy food luminous. Ivory holds the plate edge. Ochre echoes the warmth without turning the whole image yellow.

02

Secondary

Choose the largest surrounding surface. Separate the rim from its background and make the food look appetizing.



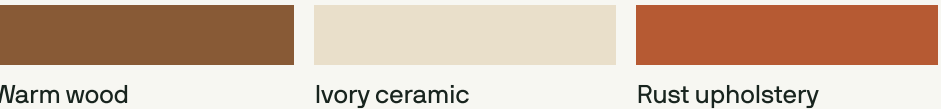
Bright field, dark ceramic

A light yellow surface lifts the dark green plate. A smaller blue element keeps the set crisp. This is a campaign set, not new SKU color coding.

03

Tertiary

Add one smaller counterpoint through glass, cloth, a chair or clothing. Omit it when the dish and surface already have enough energy.



Warm field, light ceramic

Warm wood and rust give the setting character. Ivory keeps the dish distinct. Clear glass brings light through the scene; preserve neutral whites and open shadows.

MAKE THE SET DO USEFUL WORK

Tile. Wood. Cloth. Glass.



01

Start with a surface.

Tile gives structure; painted wood gives a color field; warm wood gives intimacy. Choose one main pattern and keep the other large surfaces quieter.

02

Add a useful object.

A glass, fork, napkin or chair makes the setting believable. Choose shape, material and scale together. Each prop should explain the meal or improve the composition.

03

Leave a little life.

A moved chair, a bent napkin or a used fork gives the scene a before and after. Keep spills and crumbs intentional; avoid decorative clutter.

KEEP THE PRODUCT RECOGNIZABLE

One dish. A consistent ceramic.

Retain the curated plate language and the established package photography angle. The wider photographic world can change its distance, surface and occasion.



Jamaican Rasta Chicken Pasta

Forest / yellow brush

Retain / Deep green glaze, yellow brushwork, warm exposed rim.



Creamy Blackened Chicken Pasta

Ivory / blue brush

Retain / Warm ivory, loose blue brushwork, exposed stoneware.



Lemon Chicken Orzo

Ivory / rich blue

In review / New overhead study: smaller creamy orzo, restrained tomatoes, visible rich-blue brush glaze.



Chipotle Chicken with Corn

Ivory / chipotle brush

In review / New overhead study: irregular chicken, grouped corn, expressive deep-brown brush glaze.

90° / overhead

Best for dish recognition, ceramic shape and graphic arrangements. Keep the camera parallel to the table.

35–55° / table view

Best for food volume, glaze, glass and eating gestures. Keep the far rim visible.

Table height / setting

Best for the relationship between a meal and its surroundings. Include a chair or table edge; keep faces and full people out of frame.

START WITH THE JOB

What does this image need to do?

Job / touchpoint	Photograph	Why / composition
Win attention Homepage / campaign / paid social		Graphic table A clear silhouette and bold field read fast. Compose the copy side before placing the plate. Overhead or steep oblique
Choose a meal Menu / range / product listing		Complete dish A consistent angle and scale make comparison easy. Keep the complete rim and a clear border. True overhead; full ceramic
Want the next bite Product page / food carousel		Close appetite Texture explains the appeal that a small menu tile cannot. Focus on the cut face, sauce and one recognizable ingredient. Three-quarter close-up
See it in my day Brand story / CRM / organic social		Setting + implied presence The table and surrounding details suggest a moment in the day. Use the chair, glass and light to establish the occasion. Keep faces and full people out. Across the table or a wider setting
Feel the shared moment Social / community / editorial		Hands at the table Gestures create connection while food remains the subject. Capture the pause, action and clean table version. Overhead or dining height
Recognize what arrives Commerce / retail / delivery explanation		Package / artwork reference The exact current artwork and physical format must be clear. Keep artwork, proportions and the curated dish styling consistent. Use the established package angle

BUILD FOR THE PLACEMENT

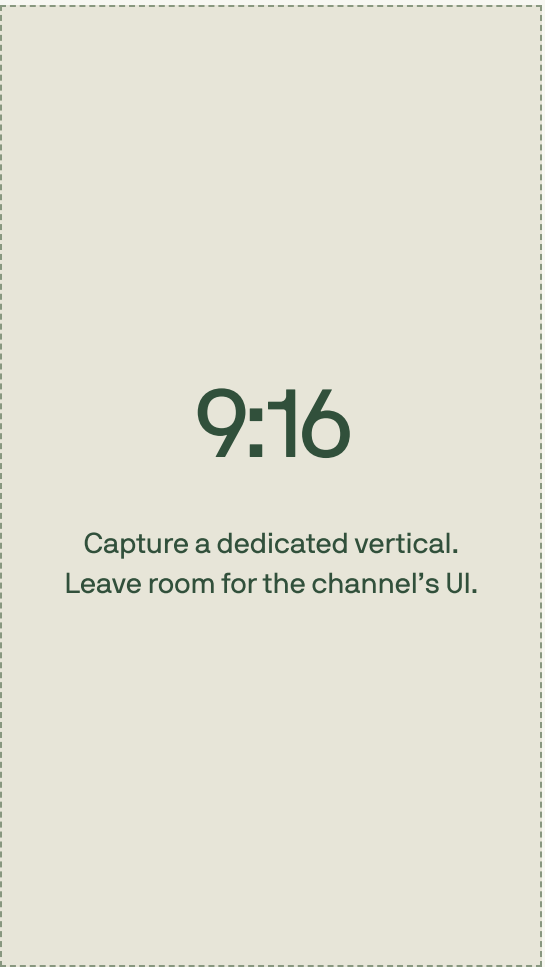
Leave space on purpose.



Landscape / compose the message side first



4:5 / food crop



01

Compose for the placement.

For a text-led hero, start with roughly one third clear space on the intended copy side. Keep strong grout lines, glass reflections and dark shadows out of the text area.

02

Shoot alternatives.

Capture left- and right-copy versions, a tighter food-only frame, 4:5 portrait and a dedicated 9:16 view. A horizontal crop is not a substitute for vertical composition.

03

Keep useful margins.

For menu images, leave about 10% beyond the rim as a starting capture margin. Check the real template. Keep important hands, food and utensils away from crop edges.

PHOTO + TYPE + SMALL GRAPHIC ACCENTS

Give each element a clear role.



Photography carries appetite and lived experience. Type carries the message. Keep iconography and illustration in margins, labels or companion panels, with room around the food.



Layout studies / not finished applications

A USEFUL LIBRARY STARTS ON SET

Capture the family, not just the hero.

01	Dish identity	Each confirmed dish: complete overhead + established packaging view.	Menu, pack and commerce continuity.
02	Appetite	One close texture and one fork-level three-quarter view per dish.	Product pages and food stories.
03	Graphic table	Hero, opposite copy side, food-only frame and clean surface.	Campaign and design flexibility.
04	Life at the table	Setting view, table view, hand gesture sequence and a clean version without hands.	Editorial, CRM and social.
05	Format coverage	Landscape, 4:5 and separately composed 9:16.	Desktop, feeds and full-screen placements.



FROM BRIEF TO DELIVERY

Keep the standard visible.

01

Before the shoot

Approve the shot list, exact dishes, ceramics, set samples, intended crops and usage. Agree who signs off food accuracy on set. Limit human presence to hands and partial gestures.

03

In the edit

Correct distractions, exposure and color. Preserve material texture, skin and honest food proportions. Do not reshape the meal or replace ingredients.

02

On set

Photograph the color target in each lighting setup. Tether to the actual layouts. Check portion, glare, hands, plate shape and focus before moving on.

04

At delivery

Supply full-resolution masters, color profile and graded sRGB web crops. Identify SKU, scene, angle, crop and version in filenames; include usage and talent permissions.

Every selected image must pass.

1. The dish is accurate and appetizing.
2. The light has one readable direction.
3. Ceramics, hands and utensils have believable scale.
4. The composition works in its actual placement.

Direction studies establish composition, light and atmosphere. They are not evidence of a final recipe, serving size or approved product photograph.

SOURCES

A curated visual foundation.



R006 / cookt



R007 / cookt



R015 / cookt



R036 / cookt



R039 / cookt



R151 / ckt2



R160 / ckt2



R217 / ckt



R218 / ckt



R233 / ckt

Reference images come from the saved pins on Julia's [cookt](#), [ckt2](#) and [ckt](#) boards. Pinterest's recommended products and suggested ideas are excluded. Original creators retain their rights; pin links are provided for source tracing.

Four new COOKT scenes and one retained close detail are AI-generated direction studies. The existing dish references keep their recorded status. Confirm product accuracy, set samples, hand-talent permissions and usage before production.